that the Ludhiana hand grab had been a breach of faith. ‘You did not keep your word,’ a fuming Nitish told Jaitley later. The BJP leader insisted that it wasn’t a deliberate act.

Two years later, though, in June 2010, Modi did rather knowingly provoke Nitish. On the eve of the BJP national executive meeting in Patna, posters and hoardings were splashed across the city thanking Modi for his contribution to the Kosi flood victims—the Gujarat government had donated a sum of Rs 5 crore. The posters had been sponsored by local BJP leaders.

Nitish, who was travelling, had invited the BJP top brass to his house for dinner during the executive meet. Lavish arrangements had been made, with food being ordered from a local five-star hotel. But when Nitish returned to Patna, he was stunned by what he saw in the papers. Full-page advertisements of the *mahadaan* (great donation) by the Gujarat chief minister to the people of Bihar were in every major daily. The text was accompanied by the Ludhiana photograph of Nitish and Modi holding hands.

Nitish was infuriated. Modi, he felt, had deliberately publicized an act of charity to humiliate him. The dinner was cancelled, and the government was pushed to the brink. ‘We can survive without them,’ Nitish told an aide.

Modi, too, was angry. ‘Why are you letting Nitish behave with me in this manner? We must pull out of the government,’ he told BJP president Gadkari. ‘That was the day when the Nitish–Modi battle took an ugly personal turn, and was no longer just about contrarian ideologies,’ says Nitish’s biographer, journalist Sankarshan Thakur.

Having just lost the 2009 general elections, though, the BJP chief didn’t want to lose another state government. The party went into damage-control mode. Jaitley and Sushil Modi were once again put on the job of placating Nitish. The 2010 Bihar elections were just a year away and the alliance had every chance of returning to power. Both sides called a truce and in the elections that followed won by a record three-fourths majority.

By the middle of 2012, though, it was apparent that Modi was the rising star in the BJP. Nitish was anxious. He made a public statement calling for